

Photograph by **MANDAR DEODHAR**

Q+A

Master of Stories

Filmmaker **Imtiaz Ali** on being a patron of the Dehradun Literature Festival, the success of *Laila Majnu* on its re-release and more

Q. The experience of being mentor and festival patron of the Dehradun Literature Festival must have been enriching.
I wouldn't call myself a mentor but a friend of the Dehradun Literature Festival (DDLF)...and I would always like to remain one. It was the first literature festival to invite me many years ago; since then, I have attended five editions. Like the movie *DDLJ*, DDLF should become the country's longest-running and best literature festival.

Q. *Laila Majnu* has become a big hit on its re-release...
It's remarkable. I don't think there has been a movie in the history of Indian cinema that has done better in its re-release. Like good books, good movies stand the test of time and become more popular over the years.

Q. What are you working on at the moment?
I am working on a few film scripts and a show for a digital platform. It'll all be coming out soon.

Q. What are you reading now?
I just finished reading Han Kang's *The Vegetarian*, which is a fabulous read. It's no surprise that she won the 2024 Nobel Prize for Literature. It's a book I'd highly recommend to anyone who is a patient reader. I have also been reading *Freedom at Midnight*, which is also a TV show now. On my reading list is *Nineteen Eighty-Four* by George Orwell.

–with Geetika Sachdev